

ECS PROJECT

CSMVS

A Look at the Architecture, Interiors, and Set-Ups of the Museum

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1 Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Vastu Sangrahalaya (CSMVS)

An ECS photo-essay documenting the architecture, interiors, and galleries of CSMVS (formerly the Prince of Wales Museum of Western India), one of Mumbai's premier heritage museums.



CSMVS, formerly the Prince of Wales Museum of Western India, is the main museum in Mumbai. It was founded in the early years of the 20th century by prominent citizens of Bombay, with the help of the government, to commemorate the visit of the Prince of Wales. It is located in the heart of South Mumbai, near the Gateway of India. The Museum was renamed in the 1990s or 2000s after Shivaji. The museum building is in the Indo-Saracenic style of architecture, incorporating elements of other styles such as the Mughal, Maratha, and Jain. The Museum building is surrounded by palm trees and formal beds, with a statue of the Prince of Wales in between.



The main staircase in the museum, after entering

The museum houses approximately 50,000 exhibits of ancient Indian history as well as objects from foreign lands, categorized primarily into three sections: Art, Archaeology, and Natural History. The Museum houses Indus Valley Civilization artefacts and other relics from ancient India from the time of the Guptas, Mauryas, Chalukyas, and Rashtrakuta. The foundation stone was laid by the Prince of Wales on 11 November 1905, and the Museum was formerly named the Prince of Wales Museum. On 1 March 1907, the government of the Bombay Presidency granted the Museum committee a piece of land called the “Crescent Site,” where the Museum now stands, following an open design competition.



A passage to the right side of the porch of the Museum



A gallery of paintings

In 1909 the architect George Wittet was commissioned to design the museum building. Wittet had already worked on the design of the General Post Office, and in 1911 would design one of Mumbai's most famous landmarks, the Gateway of India. The museum was funded by the royal visit (1905) memorial funds. Additionally, the Government and the Municipality granted Rs. 300,000, and Sir Cowasji Jehangir gave Rs. 50,000. The Museum is now maintained by annual grants from the Government and the Bombay

Municipal Corporation. The latter pays these grants from the interest accruing on the funds at the disposal of the Museum's trust.



A gallery on the second floor of the museum

The museum building was completed in 1915, but was used as a Children's Welfare Centre and a Military Hospital during the First World War, before being handed over to the committee in 1920. The Prince of Wales Museum was inaugurated on 10 January 1922 by Lady Lloyd, wife of George Lloyd, Governor of Bombay. Today this building is considered an important heritage site of the city, and it has been awarded A-grade “heritage site” status by the Government of India, along with the 2010 UNESCO Asia-Pacific Heritage Award.



The Museum from outside



The Museum from outside

Architecture: the Museum building sits on a 3-acre site with a built-up area of 12,142.23 sq. m. The building is constructed of locally quarried grey Kurla basalt and a buff-coloured trachyte Malad stone. It is a three-storied rectangular structure, capped by a dome set upon a base, which adds an additional storey at the centre of the building. It accommodates a central entrance porch, above which rises a dome tiled in white and blue flecks, supported on a lotus-petal base. A cluster of pinnacles, topped with miniature domes, surrounds the central dome. The building incorporates features like an Islamic dome with a finial, along with protruding balconies and inlaid floors inspired by Mughal palace architecture.

The architect, George Wittet, modeled the dome on that of Golconda Fort and the inner vaulting arches on those at the Gol Gumbaz in Bijapur. The interior of the museum combines the columns, railings, and balcony of an 18th-century wada (a Maratha mansion) with Jain-style interior columns, which form the main body of the central pavilion below the Maratha balcony.



The miniature domes on the top floor



The Japanese art gallery



The Japanese art gallery



Interiors of the textile gallery



Interiors of the textile gallery



The terrace of the museum